THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

ACT ONE

Written by

[Writer]

Original screenplay
Act One, Draft 2. The feature continues in Act Two.
Draft: November 2026

FADE IN:

BLACK.

Rain on a slate roof. Hundreds of small, dry clicks.

SUPER: "AUGUST 14, 1987"

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A boy's hand writes in pencil in a green cloth notebook. Pale skin. Graphite smears the edge of his palm.

On the cover: THE MARGIN. Below it: BY THEODORE LINDQVIST. PRIVATE.

The handwriting, round and careful:

> *Behind the pond there is a door. Behind the door is the back of everything. Whatever is lost goes there. Whatever is forgotten waits.*

The pencil pauses. Starts again:

> *Theodore put his ear to the door and*

The kitchen: yellow linoleum, a scarred wooden table, a round white clock over the back door reading 3:05. A plastic radio on the counter plays low.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...five past three on a wet Friday, you're with WRUT Rutland, and if you were planning a picnic, don't.

THEO (9) writes with his back to the screen door, hair hanging over his face.

The screen door bangs. Small bare feet slap across the linoleum and stop beside his chair. A five-year-old's voice:

NELL (O.S.)
Theo?

His pencil keeps moving.

NELL (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Will you come see the door?

THEO (9)
In a minute.

NELL (O.S.)
You said after lunch.

THEO (9)
I know. In a minute.

His pencil keeps moving. Nell's bare feet stand beside his chair.

NELL (O.S.)
Okay.

Her feet slap away. The screen door springs shut.

The clock's second hand sweeps. The page fills with handwriting.

Outside, the rain thins to a few clicks, then stops. The radio is loud in the quiet. The clock reads 3:26.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...clearing over the valley now.
Twenty-six past three.

Theo sets the pencil down. He turns in his chair.

The kitchen is empty. The back door stands open an inch.

Two sets of small wet footprints cross the linoleum, from the door to his chair and back out. The outgoing prints are one stride apart: a walk, not a run.

THEO (9)
Nell?

Water drips from the eaves. No answer.

A drop of water lands on the notebook page. The pencil lines blur and run.

BLACK.

THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

SUPER: "THIRTY-EIGHT YEARS LATER"

INT. STATION WAGON - MOVING - DAY

Rain taps the roof. Hundreds of small, dry clicks.

A ten-year-old station wagon packed to the roof. Boxes labeled in neat block capitals: JUNE - SCHOOL. JUNE - OTHER. THEO - BOOKS (DON'T).

THEO LINDQVIST (47) drives, long pale fingers drumming the wheel. Tall, stooped, three days of stubble, a good wool coat gone shiny at the elbows.

JUNE (12) sits beside him in an oversized hoodie, a laptop open on her knees. She watches Theo, not the screen.

Public radio plays low.

HOST (V.O.)
...from our archive. The winter Theo Lindqvist's debut, "Slate," won everything it was eligible for. It opens on a boy at a kitchen table while, across the valley, something terrible happens. Did you have that afternoon?

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
I was home. I was nine, writing at the kitchen table, and I felt it. You know how you can feel a door open somewhere in a house? I felt it in the kitchen. I didn't know what I'd felt until they came home.

Theo reaches for the dial. June turns the volume up first.

HOST (V.O.)
You've said you don't write your books. You take dictation.

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
I just try to be in the room when they arrive.

HOST (V.O.)
And if they don't?

YOUNG THEO (V.O.)
They always arrive.

June switches the radio off.

JUNE
You sound like you're about to win something.

THEO
I did win something.

JUNE
That's what I mean. So what happens when they don't?

THEO
When what doesn't?

JUNE
Arrive.

Theo smiles a second too late.

THEO
Your mother's been talking.

JUNE
Mom says you've been "between books" since I was four.

THEO
Your mother is gifted at euphemism.

JUNE
It's not a euphemism. It's a quote.

The dash screen lights up: PRIYA RAMAN - EDITOR. Theo watches it ring. It stops. ONE NEW VOICEMAIL. June taps PLAY.

THEO
June.

JUNE
It's a public car.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo, it's Priya. I'm not calling about the deadline. I'm calling about the deadline. December first. Legal has started saying "advance" in a tone. I don't need a book. I need pages. Read me one sentence out loud, like you used to. One. Call me. I love you. Call me.

Theo keeps his eyes on the road.

JUNE
Mom bet me ten dollars you'd say "in a minute" before we got there.

THEO
Did she.

JUNE
I took the other side.

She turns the laptop toward him.

JUNE (CONT'D)
It's eleven pages. It's a crossover. Will you read it?

Theo's drumming fingers stop.

THEO
In a minute.

June closes the laptop with both hands. She looks out her window.

JUNE
That's ten dollars.

The road runs along the rim of a quarry. Gray slate shelves step down to a black pond. Rain falls on the pond. The surface stays smooth: no rings, no ripples.

A gravel turnout. A granite slab with bleached plastic flowers and a mason jar of fresh orange marigolds.

June twists in her seat to read it as they pass.

JUNE (CONT'D)
"Tomas Arvidsen. Nineteen seventy-four to nineteen eighty-seven. He reached for her."
Who's Tomas Arvidsen?

THEO
A boy who lived down the road.

JUNE
He was thirteen.

THEO
He pulled my sister out of that pond. He didn't come out himself.

JUNE
Aunt Nell.

THEO
Yes.

JUNE
Are we stopping?

THEO
No.

June faces front.

JUNE
Okay.

The slab shrinks in the rearview mirror. Theo's fingers drum the wheel.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - DAY

A white clapboard farmhouse with a gray slate roof at the top of a gravel lane. A FOR SALE sign leans against the porch rail.

Beyond the field, the quarry's rim cuts a flat line across the sky.

The station wagon rolls up and stops. The engine ticks. Neither of them gets out.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

The same kitchen: yellow linoleum, a scarred wooden table, a round white clock over the back door, a plastic radio on the counter.

Gray dust coats everything. White sheets cover two chairs.

Theo stops in the doorway. June walks past him, opens the refrigerator, waves a hand at the smell, shuts it.

JUNE
It smells like a library that died.

THEO
Your grandmother was a librarian.

JUNE
Then it's accurate. There's a jar in there that used to be a pickle.

A photograph hangs on the refrigerator door under a lobster-shaped magnet. Theo at nine, all elbows, squints into the sun.

Beside him a taller boy straddles a bicycle in a red jacket, freckled hands on the handlebars. The magnet covers the taller boy's face.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Who's that?

THEO
Me.

JUNE
The other one.

THEO
A neighbor.

June reaches for the magnet. Theo's hand closes over hers.

THEO (CONT'D)
Bedrooms are upstairs. Pick one.

June looks at his hand on hers. He lifts it away.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - DAY

A forty-foot hall of worn floorboards, coat pegs along one wall.

Halfway down on the left, a door sits an inch deeper in its doorway than the others. A card thumbtacked to it reads CELLAR.

On the right, an archway to a sitting room with a dark wood-cabinet TV. At the far end, a white door, its seam filled with layers of paint.

June walks past the stairs. She goes down the hall, passes the cellar door, and stops at the white door. She turns the knob. It turns. The door doesn't move.

JUNE
It's painted shut.

Theo stands in the kitchen doorway at the other end.

THEO
It's cold-weather storage.

JUNE
Whose room was it?

THEO
Storage, June.

JUNE
That's not a whose.

THEO
Nobody's.

A floorboard creaks on the other side of the white door. June and Theo look at each other.

THEO (CONT'D)
Old house. Upstairs. Pick a bed.

June looks at the door again, then walks past him toward the stairs.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One lamp. Theo sits at the table with a legal pad, a mug of tea, and a pen. The refrigerator hums.

He closes his eyes and rests the pen on the first line. Thirty seconds pass. The refrigerator motor clicks off.

He opens his eyes. The page is blank. He writes IT WAS. Stares at it. Crosses it out.

From inside the wall behind the stove: the dry scratch of a pencil on paper. Strokes, a pause, strokes.

Theo stands and presses his ear to the plaster. The scratching travels along the wall toward the hall. He follows it three steps. It stops when he stops.

THEO
Hello?

No answer. A pipe knocks. Theo breathes out a laugh and returns to the table.

He sits and closes his eyes. The scratching starts again, softer. His shoulders drop. His head sinks onto his folded arms.

A stair creaks. June stands at the bottom of the stairs in socks and a long T-shirt, holding a glass of water. She looks at Theo asleep at the table.

She takes his coat from the chair back and drapes it over his shoulders. She tears a corner off the legal pad and writes on it. The scrap reads:

DAD - 11 PAGES. WHENEVER. -J.

She adds a smiley face. Crosses it out. Slides the scrap under his mug and goes upstairs.

The scratching in the wall continues.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING

Gray light. Birds. Theo lifts his head, a crease from his sleeve across his cheek.

Beside the legal pad lies a single sheet of cream paper with faded green rules and a deckled edge.

A child's round handwriting covers it in brown-black ink. The ink glistens.

Theo reads, lips moving.

The slate was cold on my teeth.
That is the first thing. I want to tell it in order.
It was Friday and it was raining and the kitchen smelled like wet stone. I was writing. Nell asked me to come see the door and I said in a minute.
I did not look up.

He touches the page. His fingertips come away wet. He smells them.

He takes a children's atlas from the shelf and opens the cover. In faded pencil: THEODORE LINDQVIST - GRADE 4.

The crossbars of its t's float above the stems, the same as on the page.

Theo tests the back door: bolted from inside. The windows: latched. The front door: chained.

He returns to the table. He picks up June's scrap, reads it, folds it, and puts it in his shirt pocket.

JUNE (O.S.)
What?

June stands in the doorway with a cereal box, hair flat on one side.

THEO
Did you write this?

He holds out the page. June comes closer and reads. Her lips move on the last line.

JUNE
That's not me. I write like I'm twelve, not nine.

THEO
It isn't a joke, June.

JUNE
I know it isn't. You went white.

She looks at the page, then at him.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Is it from your book?

THEO
No.

JUNE
Then who wrote it?

THEO
I don't know.

He turns the page over. The paper is buckled. Faint, reversed lines of the same handwriting show through the back. He holds it up to the window.

THEO (CONT'D)
Bleed-through.

JUNE
I didn't ask.

Theo slides the page inside a paperback on his mother's shelf: SLATE, by Theo Lindqvist, a prize sticker on its spine.

Two more of his novels stand beside it, spines aligned.

He presses his palm flat against the row of books.

INT. ALDER HILL MEMORY CARE - DAYROOM - DAY

Tall windows and a pair of glass doors face a rainy garden. A MAN stands at a window, hands clasped behind him.

Two WOMEN at a table match socks beside a half-finished jigsaw puzzle.

At a corner table INGRID LINDQVIST (79) folds washcloths: tiny, upright, white braid pinned on top of her head, cardigan buttoned one hole off.

A basin of water sits at her elbow. She dips a cloth, wrings it, folds it in thirds, stacks it.

INGRID
One in. Two in.

Theo crouches beside her chair, his back to the room. June stands behind him.

THEO
Mom.

Ingrid looks up and beams. She cups his face in her wet hands.

INGRID
Tomas! Look at you. You'll catch your death.

THEO
It's Theo, Mom.

Ingrid frowns and lets go.

INGRID
Theo's at the table. Theo's writing.

THEO
Some days.

She goes back to the washcloths.

INGRID
Tomas came back wet. Theo came back dry. I counted them both in.

At the word "wet," everyone in the room turns toward the glass doors. The man at the window. The two women. A woman with a walker in the doorway.

Then they all turn back.

June watches the residents, then the back of her father's head.

INGRID (CONT'D)
One in. Two in.
(to June)
And who's this?

JUNE
I'm June.

INGRID
You look like the other librarian.

JUNE
My mom's a conservator.

INGRID
That's what I said.

June smiles.

ELLIE (43) pushes a medication cart into the room. Navy scrubs, a name tag reading ELLIE M., RN, reading glasses on a chain. A pale band on her bare ring finger.

Ellie's face blurs whenever Theo looks at it. His eyes slide to her name tag, the cart, the window.

ELLIE
Afternoon meds, Mrs. L.

INGRID
She's always on time.

THEO
(to Ellie's name tag)
I thought the night nurse--

ELLIE
I'm covering.

Ingrid watches Theo look at the name tag.

INGRID
He doesn't see you, does he.

Ellie hands Ingrid a paper cup of pills.

ELLIE
She's tired, Mr. Lindqvist.

THEO
Of course.

ELLIE
Her windows are getting shorter. Mornings are best.

THEO
I'll try mornings.

ELLIE
Try.

THEO
We're selling the house. For the permanent wing.

Ellie looks straight at him.

ELLIE
Then come while she still knows what a house is.

EXT. ALDER HILL - PARKING LOT - DAY

Drizzle. Theo digs for his keys. June stands on the passenger side with her hood up.

JUNE
She counted two.

THEO
Two what?

JUNE
You and the other one. Every time. "One in. Two in."

THEO
She was folding washcloths.

JUNE
She said "both."

Theo gets in the car. June stays outside in the rain until he starts the engine.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The hall is dark. Light from the kitchen doorway lies across the floorboards.

Theo stands in the doorway in socks, a mug in his hand. A drip hits the floor somewhere down the hall. Another.

He flips the switch. A bare bulb lights the hall.

He walks to the cellar door and stops. Drip. He lays his palm flat against the wood.

THEO
Pipes.

He turns and walks back toward the kitchen. The dripping stops.

Behind him, at the foot of the cellar door, a wet footprint forms on the dry boards: bare, narrow, twelve inches long. Water wells up inside its outline.

Theo keeps walking. A second print forms a stride beyond the first. A third. One print every half second, heading down the hall toward the white door.

Theo steps through the kitchen doorway. A refrigerator door opens, then shuts.

The prints keep forming. The last print forms in front of the white door. Water seeps out beneath it and runs along the seam.

Under the floor: the scratch of a pencil.

A single wet slap against the white door.

Theo returns to the doorway with a milk carton in his hand. He looks down the hall. His fingers open. The carton hits the floor.

The prints run the length of the hall, from the cellar door to the white door.

He walks along them. He touches the first print with two fingers, smells them, looks at his socks. Dry.

At the white door he grips the knob. Water drips from it. He lets go and wipes his palm on his shirt.

He fetches a mop from the kitchen and mops the prints, hard and fast, from the cellar door to the white door. He mops longest in front of the white door.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - SITTING ROOM - NIGHT

The wood-cabinet TV sits dark. In its screen: a dim reflection of the lit hall.

In the reflection, Theo reaches for the light switch. Behind him, at the far end of the hall beside the white door, a tall, narrow figure stands dripping.

It is there for half a second.

Click. The hall goes dark. The screen goes black.

Under the floor, one long stroke of a pencil.

INT. SLATE DINER - MORNING

A narrow room: a counter, six booths, a framed 1952 photograph of quarrymen in caps lined up on a slate shelf. A mug sits in front of every regular.

Theo and June sit at the counter. June cuts pancakes into squares. Theo sips coffee over a blank legal pad. A WAITRESS (60s) refills his cup.

WALTER PRUITT (74) takes the stool one down from Theo: tweed jacket, hearing aid, ink stains on his cuffs. The waitress sets a coffee in front of him without being asked.

WALTER
Forgive me. You're Theo Lindqvist.

THEO
Depends who's asking.

WALTER
Nobody important. Walter Pruitt. Quarry Road, three doors past you. I read "Slate" twice, which is once more than I read most of what I wrote.

THEO
You're a writer.

WALTER
I was a ghostwriter. It's different. A writer wants to be read. A ghost wants to be believed.

JUNE
What's a ghostwriter?

WALTER
Someone who writes the book you think someone else wrote. Forty-one of them, in my case. Senators. Quarterbacks. A woman who'd been married to three of the four men she says she met in Paris. Not a name on one of them.

JUNE
That's the saddest job I've ever heard.

WALTER
It has compensations. Nobody can ever blame you.

June looks at Theo. Theo stares into his coffee.

WALTER (CONT'D)
You're writing again. By hand.

THEO
I'm not writing.

WALTER
I heard it from my porch. Pencil. All night, from your house.

THEO
I don't use a pencil.

Walter's spoon stops.

WALTER
No. I didn't think you did.

He sets the spoon down.

WALTER (CONT'D)
If anyone offers to put a name on it, don't.

THEO
On what?

WALTER
Whatever it is you're not writing.

Theo stands and walks to the register, a bill in his hand.

Behind him, wet bare footprints form on the dry linoleum, one at a time, keeping pace.

The waitress rings up the coffee. The customers keep eating. A man turns a page of his newspaper; a print forms beside his stool.

Walter's cup rattles on its saucer. He sets it down with both hands. The prints stop at the register, beside Theo's left foot.

WALTER (CONT'D)
Oh, you poor boy.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE LANE - DAY

Afternoon sun after rain. Theo walks down the gravel lane to a rusted tin mailbox and opens it.

Inside: a utility bill, a realtor's flyer, and a cream envelope, damp. No stamp. No postmark. Across the front, in a child's round handwriting:

Theodore

Theo looks up the lane, then down. Empty. His lips shape the name.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo sits at the table. The envelope lies open. Two sheets of cream paper, the same brown-black ink, the same child's hand.

He reads. A boy's voice reads with him.

BOY (V.O.)
Nell was in her yellow dress, the one with the ducks. Mom said not to wear it to the quarry. Mom said a lot of things.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAY (FLASHBACK)

Sun on wet slate, steaming. A flat black pond.

A small girl stands on a stone ledge above the water, facing the pond. Her yellow dress is printed with ducks, all facing the same direction.

BOY (V.O.)
The rain had stopped and the slate was steaming. The pond was perfectly flat. It had no sky in it. Then she wasn't on the ledge anymore.

The ledge is empty. A ring spreads across the water below it.

Freckled hands, a boy's, wade into the pond. On the ledge behind them lies a red jacket.

BOY (V.O.)
I went in. I didn't decide to. It tasted of iron. It tasted like a coin you've held in your mouth all day.

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER (FLASHBACK)

Green-black water. Sunlight breaks into coins overhead. A yellow dress sinks. The freckled hands clutch at it and come away with water.

BOY (V.O.)
I had her under the arms and then I didn't. She went out of my hands like something dropped in a well.

A bright rectangle of sky wavers at the surface. The ledge above it is empty.

BOY (V.O.)
I looked up at the ledge for someone to call. There was nobody
(MORE)

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo's finger rests on the page at the line: There was nobody on the ledge. He taps it twice.

His phone buzzes on the table. ALDER HILL.

ELLIE (V.O.)
Mr. Lindqvist? It's Ellie, from Alder Hill. Your mother's asking for you. She's in one of her windows. I thought you'd want to know.

THEO
I'm coming.

He folds the pages into his coat pocket and leaves.

INT. ALDER HILL - INGRID'S ROOM - EVENING

Gold light through the window. A narrow bed.

A shadow box by the door holds a photo of Gunnar in a quarry cap, Ingrid at a library desk, three of Theo's book jackets.

In its lower corner, a rectangle of backing is paler than the rest.

Ingrid sits in an armchair by the window, back straight, hands folded. Her eyes follow Theo across the room.

INGRID
Theo.

Theo sits on the edge of the bed and takes her hand.

INGRID (CONT'D)
You look dreadful. Are you sleeping?

THEO
Not especially.

INGRID
You never did.

THEO
Mom, I need to ask you something. It's about Nell.

Her fingers tighten on his.

THEO (CONT'D)
Do you remember her yellow dress? The one with the ducks?

Ingrid stares at him. She doesn't blink.

INGRID
Where did you get that?

THEO
I read it somewhere.

INGRID
Who told you about the ducks?

THEO
Nobody told me. It was on a page. Someone wrote it down.

Ingrid grips his wrist. Water runs from her cuff down her forearm and drips from her elbow to the floor. Theo flinches.

THEO (CONT'D)
Mom--

INGRID
You weren't there.

THEO
It says I was. It says I went in the water.

INGRID
You weren't there. You were never there. Your father--

Her eyes move to a spot behind Theo's shoulder. Her mouth goes slack.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Are you the man about the piano?

Ellie hurries in with a towel. She kneels and unpeels Ingrid's fingers from Theo's wrist, one at a time.

ELLIE
Okay, Mrs. L. I've got you.

Water drips from Theo's cuff, a wet ring around his wrist. A puddle spreads under Ingrid's chair. Ellie looks at the puddle, then at Theo's wrist. Her face goes blank.

Through the open bathroom door behind her: a dry sink.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
She's been at the sink again. She does that.

Theo looks at the bathroom door, then at the towel in Ellie's hands.

THEO
She said I wasn't there.

ELLIE
She says a lot of things.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock reads 11:38. One lamp. The window over the sink is fogged with kettle steam; beyond it, black.

Three cream pages lie fanned on the table. A cup of tea sits untouched. Theo sits and stares at the pages.

THEO
I was home.

Nobody answers. He picks up the third page and reads aloud, low and slow.

THEO (CONT'D)
"I had her under the arms and then I didn't..."

His voice finds a rhythm. His eyes close. His shoulders drop. The corners of his mouth lift.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked."

The clock reads 11:39.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody to take her hand."

His eyes open on the last line of the page. He reads it aloud.

THEO (CONT'D)
"So I reached into the black water
and took her hand, and--"

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER (FLASHBACK)

Freckled hands reach down through green-black water toward a small pale hand with open fingers.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The clock's second hand stops at 11:40. The refrigerator motor cuts out. One low tone sounds and holds.

The lamplight turns amber.

Theo opens his eyes. In the black window over the sink, his reflection sits at a table in a gold-lit kitchen. The table is scrubbed. There are no dust sheets.

The reflection is clean-shaven, its hair dry and combed. It smiles at Theo.

Theo doesn't move. The reflection stands, walks to the glass, and breathes on it. Fog spreads across the pane.

A finger writes in the fog, in the handwriting of the pages. The letters read forward to Theo:

Thank you

In the lower corner of the pane, outside, the rain streaks into the shape of a hand: palm and five fingers, spread flat.

The reflection looks at Theo and smiles. The letters run down the glass.

BLACK.

One stroke of a pencil.

END OF ACT ONE